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Surviving marriage narratively. Storytelling through women's friendships in Mary McCarthy's *The Group* (1963) and its adaptation by Lara Feigel (2020)

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ABSTRACT
This essay examines the narrative potential of novels structured by women's friendships by reading Mary McCarthy's *The Group* (1963) alongside its adaptation by Lara Feigel (2020). I look specifically at the conceptualisation of friendship through narrative voice and structure to explore the shift that is portrayed between the two novels. I show that McCarthy's novel critically examines the grouping of its protagonists and their stories based on gender with the use of free indirect narration. For the contemporary adaptation, Feigel chooses the perspective of an autodiegetic first-person narrator who diverges into third-person for extended passages to narrate her friends' lives. While McCarthy's novel exposes the implications of the conventional marriage plot for women's narratives, the entanglement of the friends' storylines in Feigel's novel suggests that these limitations have been overcome. Yet, both novels also expose that the relationships between the privileged white women protagonists are complicit with and rely on antisemitism, homophobia (McCarthy) and racism (Feigel).

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Narratives structured by friendship groups

Mary McCarthy often gets cited for something she mentioned in her application for a Guggenheim Foundation Fellowship, namely that there is no male consciousness in *The Group* (1963).[1] It has, in fact, eight women protagonists: Kay, Dottie, Helena, Pokey, Libby, Polly, Priss, and Lakey. *The Group* fuses the two modes of McCarthy's literary writing: 'witty memoirist' and 'intellectual and political satirist'.[2] The novel's 15 chapters are

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distributed unequally among the characters and across time. Vassar graduates in 1933, the women's lives separate at the beginning of the novel, and their voices take over from one another in a kind of narrative relay. The chapters are organised chronologically by the time of their narration, each covering a short period within the novel's narrative time between 1933 and 1940. Kay's story connects and frames the friends' storylines, and perhaps for that reason she has been perceived as the main character.[3]

As the title already suggests, the novel is constructed around a group identity. At the time, McCarthy was criticised by male writers who until that point had seen her as 'not a typical woman writer', and felt their assumptions betrayed when she published a supposedly 'failed novel' that was concerned with the material realities of what they considered the inconsequential part of women's private lives, including the descriptions of the technicalities of contraception, breastfeeding and housekeeping.[4] Famoulsy, Norman Mailer criticised *the group* and deemed it an irrelevant attempt at a collective novel; he specifically criticises the domestic feminity it depicts: 'the Eggs Benedict and the dress with the white fichu, the pessary and the whatnot, sit on the line of narrative like commas and periods, semicolons, italics and accents', commented Mailer.[5] Writing about the realities of women's lives, thus, was, at the time, not perceived as the author's portrayal of her generation, but rather as superficial and superfluous.

The group of protagonists is representative of McCarthy's fellow classmates at Vassar, and their depiction in the novel has been understood as an expression of the author's critique of her women contemporaries.[6] Since she did not align herself with the feminists of her time, many have interpreted the novel as an expression of McCarthy's exceptionalist claim, her 'male-identified "femininity"'; her 'problematic relationship to her characters' is emphasised, and understood as 'judgements on a feminine sphere that [she herself does] not have to inhabit'.[7] Most recently, Cassandra Fetter suggests in her contribution to Kristi Branham and Kelly L. Reames edited volume *Navigating Women's Friendships in American Literature and Culture*, 'Political Progress and Social Stall: Groupthink, Smart Talk and Mary McCarthy's Friendship Novel',[8] that *The Group* depicts a generation of women who expresses their class's claim to a progressive mindset through their materialism. Their relationship to each other mirrors this behaviour, she argues. Rather than actually caring about their friends as people, McCarthy's protagonists treat their friends as extensions of themselves. Fetters emphasises the unlikeness of the kind of friendship the protagonists share as a group and the kind of relationships McCarthy had with her friends: the lack of individuality, competition and the groupthink in the novel's friendships is in opposition to the dyadic and intellectual connections the author based on her autobiographical texts, especially *How I Grew, The Vassar Girl,* and the letters exchanged with Hannah Arendt.[9]

The Group was published in 1963, in the same year as Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* with which the novel arguably finds an accidental intellectual twin.[10] Friedan's book, which later was understood to be the spark that initiated second wave feminism, observes the declining career success of women in the 1940s and 1950s, despite the increase in their opportunities to access a college education and the success of the women's suffrage movement. Avis G. Hewitt notes that the lives of the characters in McCarthy's novel seem to correspond with what Friedan observed, yet Hewitt simultaneously argues that *The Group*'s protagonists 'could not name what was destroying their spirits because McCarthy herself could not name it.'[11] I will suggest, on the contrary, that McCarthy's novel does indeed articulate an aspect of the women's realities which kills their spirits, namely the lack of narratives available to women upon graduation from university, and especially once they are married. While McCarthy's women characters might not explicitly express what is limiting them, a close reading of the instances where the novel reflects on narrative structure does offer a feminist critique of narrative traditions. I will further suggest that the framing around a friendship group facilitates the challenge to these traditions.

The novel's plot was recently adapted to be set in present day UK by Lara Feigel. Her reworking of McCarthy's work – also called *the group* (2020) – makes considerable changes to the narrative architecture. Instead of eight friends, there are five. Four of the names are taken from McCarthy's original: Kay, Polly, Helena and Priss. Feigel adds a fifth friend, Stella, who is also the autodiegetic first-person narrator of the novel. These women, too, have a prestigious education, though between the year of their graduation from the University of Oxford and the novel's time of narration, 20 years have passed. The novel spans ten months – March to December – and is historically situated by its references to the #MeToo movement of the late 2010s. Each of the 34 chapters is named after the protagonist from whose perspective the chapter is told, alongside the relevant month – 'Stella *March*', for example. Feigel's novel thus reduces the number of voices, and the amount of time that is covered, and increases the frequency with which each protagonist is present in the narrative. While some voices are more present than others, each member of the group is allocated several chapters told from her perspective, and each character has her own narrative arc. The first-person narrative, the protagonists' age, the increased number of chapters, the alternating voices, and the distribution of the chapters among the characters and across the novel already suggest that the friendship between the women in Feigel's novel takes a different role in their lives' stories than in the original.

The two novels diverge not only on the level of narrative structure and voice: the 2020 adaptation also imagines a very different outcome for Kay. The 1963 novel ends with her funeral; but at the end of Feigel's novel, Kay survives and starts writing a novel of her own. Feigel's novel begins with

the group spending an afternoon at Priss' home, and opens with the sentence: 'We worry about not knowing our friends well enough, but sometimes we see their lives with a clarity that feels like a form of betrayal' (LF, 1).[12] A novel starting with the 'we' of a group of women is particularly intriguing in the light of Susan Lanser's article 'Second Sex Economics: Race, Rescue, and the Heroine's Plot'[13] who examines alliances between women in the history of the heroine's marriage plot in English and German eighteenth-century novels. She specifically looks for examples where women rescue other women from economic and social misery. She finds that

> to the extent that economic and social inequality is tacitly accepted as the unarticulated price of marital resolution, […] [18th-century same-sex rescue plots are] complicit both with the subordination of women that Beauvoir describes and with the intersecting subordinations wrought by colonialism and race.[14]

Nonetheless, she argues that, even if these plots do not accomplish to imagine different social realities, they do 'expose the more than symbolic grounding for a novel politics in which women might, indeed, say "we"'.[15]

McCarthy's novel do not say 'we', but Feigel's protagonists do. McCarthy's Kay dies, while Feigel's survives, turning Feigel's adaptation into a rescue plot. Taking inspiration from Lanser's article, I will contrast narrative structure and narrative voice of the two novels, asking which narrative forms in Feigel's novel enable the imagination of different social realities that were not available in McCarthy's. Feigel's adaptation therefore also offers an insight into how the politics of the novel have changed, especially as McCarthy's original was published before what Christy Rishoi calls the 'massive cultural shift in point of view about the experiences of womanhood' that developed alongside a shift in narrative paradigms in second wave feminism.[16] Both of the novels I am analysing focus on groups of women who are all white and privileged by their class. Since Lanser suggests that a focus on the relationships between women exposes the intersection of gender with race and socio-economic circumstances, I will inquire in particular how the subjectivities and friendships of the women are constructed in interdependency with white ignorance, racism and class privilege in light of the novel's contexts – the white middle class of midcentury US-America and contemporary UK, respectively.

Friendship as rescue plot

McCarthy's *The Group* starts with Kay's wedding, in June 1933,[17] and ends in July 1940 with her funeral. Both events – the wedding and the funeral – bring together all members of the group, which does not meet in that constellation at any other point in the novel.[18] The first sentence of the novel appears to comment on the expectations of women's narratives: It was June 1933, one

week after Commencement, when Kay Leiland Strong, Vassar '33, the first of her class to run around the table at the Class Day dinner, was married to Harald Petersen […]. (MM, 5).[19] The trajectory in the direction of marriage of the protagonists' stories is depicted as self-evident: Kay is differentiated from her year group by the point in time she gets married, yet the narrator's phrasing implies that the others will follow in her footsteps eventually. The friends' gender inevitably creates an expectation that the narrative will follow the convention of the marriage plot, ergo that the novel will track each of the characters' path to married life.[20] Mary-Catherine Harrison summarises that the marriage plot 'normalized a particular set of heterosexual gender roles' and focuses on one heroine and one hero.[21] It is characterised by its ending, 'the […] "happily ever after"' that 'associates courtship with conflict and marriage with resolution and goal'.[22] The very first sentence of McCarthy's novel, with its reference to Kay's marriage, ironically exposes the cultural expectation that women's stories lead to marriage. It also highlights that the novel doubly subverts the marriage plot: it neither complies with the convention of the marriage at the end of the story (since it happens at the start), nor with the focus on a single heroine.

There are further complications. The setting of the novel around a friendship group, where one woman gets married at the beginning of the novel, implicitly sets the narrative expectation of a sequence of women getting married over the course of the novel. This plot structure queers the marriage plot because, serialisation, as Robyn Warhol has argued, resists the narrative closure that is usually required by the marriage plot's heterocentrism.[23] By continuing to delay the happy ending by offering instances of closure that turn out to be either provisional or temporary, the serial form contributes to the undermining of the marriage plot.[24] Neither a wedding at the start, nor any following wedding, can provide the narrative closure it is supposed to deliver. The framing of the friends' story by Kay's wedding and death also insinuate that McCarthy's text alludes to what will later be explicated by Rachel Blau DuPlessis: 'Once upon a time, the end, the rightful end, of women in novels was social—successful courtship.'[25] Even their prestigious (Vassar) education does not change the women's life paths; which perhaps triggered the 'shock of intellectual leaders at the book's heavy cargo of womanish inconsequence' that is mentioned in a contemporary review.[26] The particular structuring of McCarthy's novel that tells the friends' lives alongside Kay's suggests that her storyline acts as a reflection on women's narratives overall, and her character arc will therefore serve as the focus when I further examine the entanglement of gender and narrative in McCarthy's novel.

Feigel's first-person narrator, Stella, makes the most consequential changes to the narrative structure of the original, both in form and in

content. As the only character who does not share a name with any of the protagonists in McCarthy's original, her name already sets her apart from and even above the other four friends ('Stella' translates to star). The character's employment in a publishing house further emphasises her role as the editor. She also has the most dominant and distinguishable voice in the novel, 15 of the 34 chapters are narrated from her perspective, and she has the first and the last word. This arguably suggests that Stella and the first-person narrative are the change that saves Kay and that makes women's stories narratable beyond the marriage plot:

> She and I met doing Drama […]. I was attracted to her, I think. […] She met Harald on the drama scene as well: theirs is the only marriage among our group that began then. Harald was an American graduate student who acted well. […] I met him first and was attracted to him as well – I think Kay and I often have similar taste in men. We flirted at parties and there were a couple of times when I managed to leave alongside him and we walked through the night together, our shoes clicking in time, but he wasn't interested in me. And then he and Kay met on stage in our third year as, of all combustible combinations, Macbeth and Lady Macbeth. (LF, 14)

The narrator's experience appears to foreshadow her friend's story: Stella was attracted to both Kay and Harald before the two of them became a couple. Her desire chronologically precedes their marriage, which was the first marriage of any members of *the group*. But the change to a bisexual autodiegetic first-person narrator who is a member of the group has further narrative implications. Lanser distinguishes between queer narrators who are out to the reader – heterodiegetic queer narrators – and those who in 'the confessional mode […] confide[s] sexual secrets only to another character': homodiegetic queer narrators.[27] Stella's bisexuality is heterodiegetic and does not take the form of a confession. Its positioning at the relative beginning, rather than later on in the novel suggests that her queerness is a building block and precondition of the narrative rather than a narrative event. Moreover, the fact that the passage above is situated in Kay's introductory chapter, rather than Stella's first chapter, suggests that Stella's bisexuality is not key to her characterisation as a protagonist. Its key relevance is to Kay's storyline.

In her analysis of the queering narratological characteristics of Winterson's *Written on the Body*, Lanser argues that to queer narrative means to move beyond the binaries of narratological categories: 'to let it deviate from the straight-and-narrow path of structuralism's binaries into a more dauntingly indeterminate terrain'.[28] That also means, she argues, to allow the tension between several possible readings of a text to co-exist, instead of aiming to resolve it. Rather than depicting couples who might engage in a heteronormative marriage plot, Feigel's novel creates a triangle between Harald, Kay and Stella that enables several alternative imaginations. One alternative story world is a romantic relationship between Stella and

Harald; in this version Kay functions as Stella's alter-ego, a friend who lives the life she might have lived. Another imaginable narrative is a romantic relationship between Kay and Stella: the friendship between the two women would then resist the binary between a platonic and a romantic relationship, and Stella would not be subsumed under Kay's and Harald's marriage as the supportive best friend character.

Feigel's decision to narrate *the group* from the perspective of a bisexual woman thus has narrative implications. It brings into focus the dyadic friendship between the two women: friendship is depicted as a relationship with another self, but also as a same-sex relationship with romantic and sexual potential. As such, the friendship between Stella and Kay claims equal status to heterosexual relationships but is not collapsed into a heteronormative reading in which it can only exist as either a platonic friendship or a monogamous lesbian relationship. Stella's attraction to Kay is neither subordinated to a heteronormative marriage plot in which the queer desire of the protagonists is often limited to the unruly narrative middle:[29] the continued existence of Stella's and Kay's friendship alongside their respective marriages suggests that Stella's queer desire is not a conflict that needs to be overcome in the search for the right heterosexual relationship. Feigel's bisexual narrator therefore challenges these traditional narrative binaries in which the supposedly wrong choices of the narrative middle are left behind in favour of the perfect coupling. The framing of the novel around friendship allows for a simultaneity of possible readings, each of which offer different insights into conventional novel politics.

'All sorts of weird irrelevant ideas floated through Dottie's head'

In both novels, the protagonists' friendship is captured in an omniscient narrative voice. Brenda Murphy describes how, in McCarthy's novel, (apart from the first and last chapters, in which the group speaks as a chorus) 'each of the other chapters is told essentially from one character's point of view in free indirect discourse'.[30] She suggests that, as a result, the characters' perspectives are depicted through talk rather than through their focalisation, and each event is either imagined as a future conversation or told through the lens of a previous conversation: 'each of these young women perceives life filtered through the term of a running narration', which manifests either as 'a rehearsal for performing for the group, or The Group's composite voice running in her head'.[31] Kelly A Marsh proposes an even stronger influence of the group identity. She emphasises that the narrative voice expresses the similarity of the women: a 'collective voice that is the expression of a type'.[32] She argues that the collective voice precedes the individual and suggests that the friends are not fully aware of how similar they

are to one another.[33] I will argue that the use of free indirect style allows for a reading of *The Group* which is more ambivalent than the focus on the collective and a 'type' suggests.

Free indirect style, D.A. Miller argues in his book *Jane Austen or the Secret of Style,* draws attention to the shifting boundary between the character whose perspective is described in the third person, and the narrator.[34] In Jane Austen's novels, which are considered pioneering in and exemplary of this style in the history of the English novel,[35] Miller observes that the narrative voice 'is constantly both mimicking, and distancing itself from, the character's way of *seeing*'.[36] Miller proposes that this style of narration, rather than offering the omniscient perspective for which free indirect style is generally known,[37] can be best understood as coming 'as close as possible to the character's psychic and linguistic reality without collapsing into it'.[38] In this way, the free indirect narrative voice exposes the character's limitations, because '[a]fter all, how would even the cleverest character divine that he or she is being narrated?'.[39] The narrative voice in McCarthy's novel fits this model very well. The second chapter tells the story of how Dottie has sex for the first time:

> Just at first, in the dark hallway, it had given Dottie rather a funny feeling to be tiptoeing up the stairs only two nights after Kay's wedding to a room right across Harald's old room, where the same thing happened to Kay. An awesome feeling really, like when the group all got the curse at the same time; it filled you with strange ideas about being a woman, with the moon compelling you like the tides. All sorts of weird, irrelevant ideas floated through Dottie's head as the key turned in the lock and she found herself for the first time, alone with a man in his flat. (MM, 30)

At first, this is undoubtedly Dottie's point of view because the narration merges with her perceptual field and emotional reality: the darkness of the hallway, and the 'funny feeling' as she recognises the similarities between herself and Kay. Then, the narration seems to exit Dottie's character partially and shifts into a generalising 'you', as she considers the parallels between her and Kay's experiences and then those of the members of the group. The second person here could be Dottie making a general claim in the sense of 'one', but might also address Dottie herself, as a representative of the group, or as representative of women in general.[40] Monika Fludernik has argued that readers tend to naturalise any narrative voice and therefore assume that a spoken 'you' implies an 'I' who speaks.[41] Depending on who is addressed in this passage, however, either Dottie or the narrator could be speaking. This ambivalence is further emphasised when the narrative voice then seems to move further away from Dottie, summarising her thoughts as 'weird, irrelevant ideas' (MM, 30). In line with what Miller describes about the tone of Austen's narrative voice, McCarthy's narrator

seems simultaneously to ventriloquise Dottie's observations, and to cast them aside.

'It's me, her friend Stella'

Like McCarthy's group of friends, Feigel's protagonists are very similar to each other. Though, different from the friends in McCarthy's novel in which commonalities are desired, Feigel's protagonists overly emphasise even the slightest differences. The artifice in creating these boundaries is summarised towards the end of the novel, where it reads like an explanation of their group dynamics:

> We insist on our minor differences: I am the one who never finishes her tea, Polly finds it hard to choose which cake to have because she's tempted by all of them but also to renounce cake altogether. We characterise ourselves, like characters in novels. But we look almost identical to onlookers in our wealth, our privilege, our freedom of choice. And more importantly, these characters are so arbitrary: we could swap them between us at will. […] Yet we insist on each other's otherness, even as we fear it. Because our sameness disturbs us even more. (LF 321)

Stella describes the London white middle-class world of the 2010s: hobbies like yoga, baking and singing, unfinished cups of tea and an abundance of cake suggest financial security and leisurely periods of time spent with free time activities and catching up with friends at coffee houses. That their obvious sameness is even more disturbing to them than their differences suggests that a neoliberal awareness of their privilege creates a discomfort they ignore by focusing instead on inconsequential differences. In Feigel's novel, the challenge to telling women's narratives is not their limitation to ending either with marriage or death. Instead, *the group* emphasises a lack of narratives in which women relate to one another across differences that are more substantial than trivial preferences. In the passage above, this lack is closely linked to the protagonists' whiteness and class.

Feigel's omniscient autodiegetic first-person narrator who switches between retrospectively telling her own story and the stories of her friends' uses a popular contemporary narrative style to depict the narrative difficulties her protagonists are facing. Paul Dawson and Filippo Pennacchio suggest that the use of homodiegetic first-person omniscient narrators in contemporary fiction should not be viewed through the lens of paralepses – defined originally by Genette as narrative excursions into omniscience and third-person narration: passages in which 'information [is given] that should be left aside'.[42] They have since at least the mid-1990s become more and more common,[43] and are frequent enough that they can no longer be considered unconventional.[44] Dawson similarly observes their prevalence in contemporary fiction: 'novels over the past few decades […]

collectively have developed "first-person omniscience" as virtually another category of narrative voice'.[45] To evaluate the function of first-person omniscience, both scholars think that considering them as rhetorical strategies is more productive than sticking to Genette's epistemological focus. In other words, while Genette's framing highlights instances where a particular narrator becomes unreliable because they exhibit knowledge that they cannot have, Dawson and Pennacchio ask which imagination is performed in this narrative act. Accordingly, the fact that Stella narrates her friend's lives while she is absent from it, is not particularly interesting. However, the act of friendship that is represented through this imaginative act, is.

Pennacchio argues that omniscience in contemporary novels often 'confront us with a series of contradictions while at the same time solving them'.[46] One of the contradictions he mentions is between 'the impossibility of embracing what happens in the mind of others', and 'the chance – if only – in the form of an imaginative act – to fully grasp it'.[47] This resonates with the end of the first chapter:

> Nothing very eventful happens to us, but that gives more work for the ethnographer in me to get to work. […] I hope that when I write about them [her friends], there might be a form of clear-sightedness that feels less like betrayal than love. (LF, 12)

Stella hopes that the knowledge she has of her friends can be transformed by the act of writing. Turning their experiences into stories, even though their lives do not fulfil traditional expectations of narrative, is portrayed as a loving gesture. Imagining someone's story, thus, becomes an act of friendship in Feigel's novel. Stella's search for a loving perspective on her friends' lives could therefore perhaps be understood as Dawson has put it: 'a post-postmodern move beyond metafiction because it draws attention […] to the artifice of the fiction, but locates the authorial figure within the diegesis, providing a characterological motivation for the reflexive experimentation with conventions of omniscience'.[48]

Over the course of the novel, the narrative voice that narrates Kay's storyline shifts from a first-person narrative with extensive excursions into the third-person to chapters that are entirely narrated in the third-person. In Kay's introductory chapter, Kay *March,* Stella's 'I' is present throughout, both when she is present sharing the physical space with Kay, and when she is not. In the following chapters narrated from her perspective, Kay *July*, and in Kay *September,* Stella's 'I' only appears in a couple of paragraphs. For the remaining four chapters about Kay's storyline, the first-person perspective is entirely absent. The retreat of the first-person perspective in Kay's storyline suggests that, in order for Kay's voice to emerge, Stella's and Kay's storylines need to be separated. The alternating shifts between first-person and third-person narrative in Feigel's novel represent this separation of

the friends' identities, the lack of which McCarthy's narrative voice ridicules in *The Group*.

Just like in McCarthy's storyline, the author's biography overlaps with details of the protagonists. While in McCarthy's case, research on *The Group* has highlighted the overlaps between the author and Kay,[49] Feigel has commonalities with both Stella and Kay. Among other aspects, the author shares the Jewish background and the family constellation with Stella. With Kay, she shares the element which arguably epitomises the difference between the original and the adaptation that rescues the protagonist: she experiences freedom in spending time away from her nuclear family in a holiday home which she bought together with a friend. In Feigel's memoir, this home away from home, plays a central role in helping her feel less trapped in her nuclear family life. The author points out the exclusive middle-class nature of this freedom,[50] a middle-class privilege she shares with her protagonist. However, while acknowledging class privilege as a condition for this freedom, it is the nature of her friendships which differentiate Feigel's Kay from McCarthy's Kay. In the next section, I will argue that the friendships in Feigel's adaptation subvert heteronormative storytelling, while in McCarthy's original only the lesbian relationship is able to overcome patriarchal narratives.

Narrative handover

At the end of McCarthy's novel, Lakey returns to America from Europe, together with her partner Maria, when all seven friends are reunited for the duration of a few weeks before Kay's death. The group spends this time reflecting on Lakey's and Maria's relationship and the new information it brings them about Lakey's sexuality. While the friends overcome their initial uncertainty about how to approach the couple, they are not able to shake off heteronormative stereotypes:

> On the one hand, there were Lakey-and-Maria, as you might say Polly-and-Jim, a contented married pair; on the other, there was an exquisite captive of a fierce robber woman, locked up in a Castle Perilous, and woe to the knight who came to release her from enchantment. But it was possible to see it the other way around. Supposing it were Lakey, who had made poor Maria, who was not very bright, her prisoner and slave? The fact that it was possible to reverse the relation like an hourglass was what the girls found so troubling. (MM, 344, 345)

McCarthy invokes medieval Christian imagery in the group's reflection on the lesbian relationship. In *The Arthurian Legend* by Thomas Malory, the word 'perilous' is associated with the quest to prove a protagonist's knighthood and his worthiness of finding the holy grail. Merlin calls the empty seat at the round table, reserved for the knight who retrieves the holy grail, 'the

siege perilous'.[51] In at least two scenarios, the word is related to a knight's quest to prove his knighthood and safeguard his virginity. When Lancelot is lured into the frightening chapel perilous and retrieves a sword from it without getting misled by the illusions that are presented to him, Hellawes, who has been in love with him for several years, requests a kiss in exchange for the sword, which he denies her. Hellawes dies shortly afterwards of sorrow.[52] In a similar quest to prove his knighthood and safeguard his virginity, Arthur's nephew Gareth is sent on a task to save Lyonesse from four knights who keep her captive at the castle perilous. After defeating the four knights, Gareth is tempted to sleep with Lyonesse before marrying her, which is prevented with magic by Lyonesse's sister Lyonette.[53] Even if we ignore the heteronormative symbolism of the swords and the grail, these examples reveal a gender dynamic by which the male protagonist has to prove his value as a knight by resisting seduction, and by saving the (right) woman. This narratively naturalised dynamic of heterosexual couples is exposed and troubled in *The Group* when the friends realise that they cannot apply it to the lesbian couple. Several stories become thinkable: it is not easily determined which of the two, Lakey or Maria, is the seductress. One might be tempted to think it must be Maria because she is the 'outsider' to the group, yet her name contradicts the association of her with the role of a seductress. The chronological order of the romantic plot loses its directional logic, and appears to be reversible like an hourglass, as the friends observe in the quote above.

The last chapter of *The Group* thus suggests that a story structured by a lesbian relationship will upset narrative traditions. It also upsets (male) narrative authority. McCarthy's novel ends with a conversation between Lakey and Harald in the car on the way back to New York from Kay's funeral. Harald suspects that he is thought to 'have done away with her' (MM, 345), and finds different people to blame for Kay's fatal fall from the window. At first, he blames Kay herself, (MM, 345) then he blames Lakey and suggests by invoking homophobic beliefs that she 'corrupt[ed] the whole group' (348). Finally, he requests to be let out of the car, and the novel ends with Lakey's view:

> She drove on following the cortège, watching him in the rear-view mirror as he crossed the road and stood, thumbing a ride, while cars full of returning mourners glided past him, back to New York. (MM, 348)

The last passage of the novel underlines the outdatedness of Harald's perspective in multiple ways: he is disappearing in the rear-view mirror, and is left behind by the cars driving past him. Lakey has the last words of the novel, which, given that *The Group* does not include a chapter told from her perspective, suggests that her story is about to begin, and links it with Harald being left behind.

In Feigel's adaptation, among Stella's friends, Kay receives the highest number of chapters. Her storyline starts right in the second chapter – Kay *March*. After that, there is only one short chapter during the summer months narrated from her perspective, where she literally and metaphorically loses her voice (LF, 141). This incident is placed right at the centre of the novel: in the ninth chapter, 'Kay *July*'. In the last third of the novel, Kay's voice is increasingly foregrounded. The 18th chapter, 'Kay *September*', the 20th chapter, 'Kay *October*', two chapters in November: the 23rd, and the 26th chapters, two December chapters, the 31st, and the second-to-last, the 33rd chapter, are all told from her perspective. The development of Kay's storyline development suggests a reading of *the group* by which Stella's voice performs an act of friendship: it makes space for Kay to find her voice, and creates the conditions for her to write her novel.

Similar to McCarthy's, Feigel's Kay has given up her plan to pursue a creative career (here, she was on route to become a writer), while her husband does pursue the profession. Stella describes how Harald takes up space in his and Kay's home after their marriage:

> I remember going to their tiny Hampstead flat and hearing him pacing around, reciting not just his own lines but everyone else's. I was co-opted – we all were – into running through the scenes with him. Once after I went home from a late dinner, leaving the kitchen crowded with fetid fishbones, I remember thinking of Kay, trying to write, unable to escape the sound of iambic pentameter bouncing off the walls at her. (LF, 17)

Harald's voice is taking up space in this passage in multiple ways. He speaks for everyone in the play (Shakespeare's *Hamlet*) for which he is practising and, by claiming the house as a space that serves his career, makes it impossible for Kay to write. By involving Kay's friends in rehearsing his role of Horatio, he extends their and the house's function as a sounding board for his career. The reference to a play by Shakespeare here comments on the implications of Harald's use of his voice: Horatio in *Hamlet* is the one who survives to tell the tale, and his name has been understood as linked to the Latin words ratio[54]– *reason* – and orator[55] – *speaker*. Horatio therefore encompasses the roles of the narrator – the one who creates – and of the reader – the one who makes sense of the story. Further, Horatio is present for pivotal moments of the play, namely for the sighting of the ghost: he is the one who commands the ghost to speak,[56] which means that he is also a protagonist with considerable agency. By associating Harald with Horatio, Feigel highlights the implications of what it means to be the one who speaks and is heard: the narrator is bestowed with agency and credibility – when he speaks, his reasoning is believed. Where McCarthy's novel highlights the gendered nature of narrative plot, Feigel's text focuses on the questions of voice and agency: Kay's voicelessness is presented as gendered, which is continued throughout the novel.

At the beginning of Kay's narrative arc, Stella introduces her as someone who was supposed to be a writer. She had wanted to write fiction, and was, according to Stella, cut out for it. At university, it was already clear that she 'was going to be a novelist' (LF, 14), and Stella reflects that 'it made sense of her combination of withdrawn observation and stagey wit. She wrote methodically every day' (LF, 14). In the same chapter, Harald and Kay host a dinner party to which they have invited a few friends and colleagues of Harald's, 'three novelists, all male' (LF, 29), a journalist, and Stella. During that evening, it is suggested twice to Kay that she should start writing again, first by one of the three novelists 'who may or may not be called Stephen' (LF, 31). Kay's inability to remember the names of any of the three novelists suggests that these three stand in for the men she encounters in her day-to-day life, middle-aged and middle-class British *white* men, whose encouragement does not seem to resonate with Kay. It appears that neither Kay nor Stella take 'Stephen's' judgement seriously. However, when Stella too suggests Kay should write, towards the end of the chapter, just before leaving the house, it, 'doesn't strike [Kay] as irrelevant' (LF, 38). Arguably, it is at this moment – the moment one of her friends suggests she should write a story – that Kay's narrative arc begins.

Before she can start to write, however, Kay first loses her voice, literally and figuratively. This happens halfway through the novel, in the fifth of 10 months, which is also halfway through the timeline of the novel. The loss of her voice is contextualised in the dynamics of the nuclear family. Foregrounded is the changing relationship with her oldest child, with whom she increasingly has to argue, and her husband who overrules her decisions in her absence, and accuses her of simulating her voicelessness: he 'discounts everything she says because he's convinced, that if she wanted to, she could do more than a whisper' (LF, 144). After that, Kay increasingly disengages from social interaction. This is apparent in the next chapter which is written from her perspective, 'Kay *September*'. Kay's desire to be alone peaks when the reader learns in 'Kay *October*' that she has left her house and taken the train to a friend's empty holiday home in Cornwall, where she spends a couple of weeks on her own before Stella follows and eventually returns with her.

In Kay's last chapter, which is the penultimate chapter of the book, Kay is back in the domestic setting of her introductory chapter 'Kay *March*', and of 'Kay *July*', where she lost her voice. However, now she has started to write a novel, and the relationship with her husband appears to have changed. They have carved out time for her to work on her novel (LF, 309), and their conversations are different as well:

> Before he takes Seb off for his story, Harald asks her courteously about her writing and she realises that it's years since she asked him about his. […]

> She asks, feeling oddly formal, about his writing and he says that he is rewriting. She realises that she can't remember and may never even have known what this novel is about. (LF, 325)

The use of the word 'courteous' suggests that Harald is making an effort to change the dynamics in their relationship. This is reflected by the fact that he is in the process of rewriting his novel, which implies that his voice is also changing. That Kay has found her writing voice is however not only related to a shift in her domestic relationships, but also to her ignorance around her whiteness and class:

> In the past, she's said that one reason she doesn't write is that she dislikes her voice – the white middle-class voice our group shares. But she doesn't feel hindered by it now, the way she's writing feels more universal. (LF, 310)

Retrospectively, it becomes clear that Kay's inability to write was also related by her inability of coming to terms with her class and white privilege. Given the lack of any reported reflection on her privilege, the claim to a universal voice is surprising. Later in the chapter, when she talks to a mother in a café, universality is brought up again: "the easy conversation that makes possible a community of parents everywhere, however much we resist it" (LF, 311). The experience of parenting enables a type of conversation about "sleeping and feeding and crawling" (LF, 311) that, so she believes, relates parents to one another. While the restriction put on Kay's voice through her heteronormative marriage seems to have started to shift, how it is affected by her class and her whiteness has not been addressed. In the following section, I will examine how antisemitism and racism is prevalent in the friendship groups in the two novels.

Narrative ignorance

In Mary McCarthy's novel, the women of the group very much identify in contradistinction to their parents' generation, whom they regard as conservative in matters of gender and antisemitism:

> They were a different breed, they could assure the curate, from the languid buds of the previous decade: there was not one of them who did not propose to work this coming fall, at a volunteer job if need be […]. The group was not afraid of being radical either […]. The worst fate, they utterly agreed, would be to become like Mother and Dad, stuffy and frightened. Not one of them, if she could help it, was going to marry a broker or a banker or a coldfish corporation lawyer like so many of Mother's generation. […] It would be better, yes, they were not afraid to say it, to marry a Jew if you loved him – some of them were awfully interesting and cultivated, though terribly ambitious and inclined to stick together […]. (MM, 12, 13)

The performance of a radical politics that resists the antisemitic bias of the parental generation is exposed merely as a need for differentiation, and ultimately as a double standard, when the narrator shifts into antisemitic

stereotypes. In his article *Anti-Semitism and Midcentury U.S. Fiction*, Will Norman suggests that McCarthy is 'perhaps the most important figure for an account of complicity in midcentury U.S. literature, by virtue of her relentless and aggressive interrogation of the moral life of liberal intellectuals'.[57] He argues that, in McCarthy's work, the complicity of liberal characters in antisemitism becomes apparent through linguistic betrayal, specifically in the use of the word 'them'.[58] In the quotation above, the already revealing phrase, 'they [the group] were not afraid to say it', could still be read as a testimony to the societal climate at the time; but the use of '[some of] them' is followed by antisemitic stereotypes.

None of the members of McCarthy's group marries a Jewish person. The topic is picked up again, however, when Priss runs into Norine in the second to last chapter of the book. Norine, an outsider to the group, married a Jewish man called Freddie and had a child with him, Ichabod. In the conversation between Priss and Norine, both women employ antisemitic stereotypes as they talk about Freddie and Ichabod, which suggests that the protagonists of McCarthy's novel, as Fetters argues, had 'mindlessly embrace(d) the leftist politics of the time',[59] a fact which is revealed in this late chapter in the novel Norine is more outspoken about how her son might be perceived by Harald, who once again stands in for the stereotypical white man, and even uses the pejorative term Y**. Priss demonstrates the double standard of being uncomfortable with Norine's use of the derogatory term on the one hand, but quietly complying with antisemitic sentiments on the other. When she discovers that Ichabod is circumcised, she feels 'guiltily glad that Stephen did not have a Jewish father. It struck her, awful as it sounded, that if you wanted to give your child the best start in life, you would not marry a Jew' (MM, 310).

In his article 'In Praise of Depth: or, How I Stopped Worrying and Learned to Love the Hidden', Joshua Landy argues that the free indirect discourse, offers the opportunity to play a trick on the reader. His example is Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*, in which, he argues, the reader will follow Lizzie's perspective and mistake it for the narrator's. At first, readers will interpret, like Lizzie, Mr Darcy's behaviour as arrogance, and will only understand later that how he carried himself initially was an expression of concern, not of arrogance. Landy proposes that this trick is inbuilt into the text through indirect discourse, and that all readers will fall for it. Like Lizzie, the reader will perhaps realise that they should question the stereotypes which inform their first impressions. Similarly, McCarthy's novel will leave the reader of her novel at first under the impression that the protagonists are critical of their parents generation's antisemitism and segregational beliefs.[60] Only by the end of novel, the supposedly radical claims of the group are uncovered as lies that served as tools of self-construction. In the end, Priss keeps up the segregation that the parental generation

had supported: after this meeting with Norine she chooses a new location in the Park to which she takes her son, in order to avoid her (MM, 328). The reader, now better informed about the group, will recognise the hypocrisy even if they might not remember the beginning of the novel. Different than in the passage about Dottie which I have discussed above, the free indirect discourse does not deliver the critique immediately and transparently along with the protagonist's perspective. Instead, the reader is required to notice the critique themselves.

Where McCarthy exposes the group's complicity in antisemitism, Feigel's novel addresses the racism of the group. The novel centres on white people, and Black people only appear at its margins. Polly dates a colleague of hers, Sam, who is Black. After she has broken up with Sam, she dates Dave, who is also Black. Her focalised perspective presents Blackness as an aesthetic characteristic, for example when Polly observes the contrast between her skin's colour and Sam's:

> As always, she likes the contrast between her pale skin and his dark skin. Her hands are no more white than his cheeks are black, she thinks, examining them; it would be more accurate to say orangey-pink and dark brown. (LF, 83)

Polly's naivety or culpable ignorance is further emphasised when she dates Dave:

> Dave is the first man that Polly has slept with since Sam. When she selected him from the grinning faces lined up on her computer, she told herself that choosing another black man had nothing to do with Sam and this was better than going out of her way to choose someone different. (LF, 155)

The phrase 'this was better' suggests that there could be moral significance to dating a series of Black men that Polly could reflect on; but Polly's self-inquiry stops at the implications of her emotional attachment to Sam; she does not interrogate her own pattern of being attracted to Black men. The objectification of Black men's bodies is again in evidence when Helena tells her uncle Vince that she is having a baby with her friend Aaron:

> She sits […] explaining the situation to Vince, who asks to see a picture of Aaron, and she finds one on her phone.
>
> You'll have a beautiful child, he says. (LF, 119)

Vince's reaction to the picture of Aaron reproduces the bi-racial beauty stereotype.[61] In his foreword 'Black Maleness as a Deleterious Category' to the edited collection *Appealing Because He Is Appalling: Black Masculinities, Colonialism and Erotic Racism,* Tamari Kitossa argues that Black masculinity continues to be constructed through sexualised objectification, and that sexual exploitation is one of the dominant avenues through which Black men experience racist violence.[62] The white characters of Feigel's novel

engage uncritically in this form of discrimination. The men of Colour who appear in the narrative are either discussed in a framework of neoliberal colour blindness, or through racist stereotypes in particular through the objectification of Black male bodies.

The five protagonists do not have any friendships with women of Colour. The only women of Colour that appear in the novel are a girl who comes as an urgently referred patient of Polly's into the hospital for genital reconstructive surgery, and her mother. This highlights that the only point of contact between the protagonists and women of Colour is in a professional context.[63] Only at the end of the novel, Kay engages in a conversation with a woman of Colour:

> [Kay] goes to the Caffè Nero near Hammersmith station and finds that she is sitting across from a woman with a tiny baby. […] Now when she looks, she catches the mother's eye and they smile at each other. […] How old? She asks, and is told two weeks. She reaches out, before she's had time to ask herself whether it's an appropriate thing to do, and strokes the pale brown foot which pokes out from the Babygro. […] They talk now about sleeping and feeding and crawling, the easy conversations that make possible a community of parents everywhere, however much we resist it. Then the woman leans over unexpectedly and touches the scar on her cheek. (LF, 311)

The interaction between the two women happens on an equal footing since they sit at the same table. Glances and touches are exchanged reciprocally and spontaneously. Throughout the scene, Kay is worried about how her actions will be perceived when she repeatedly looks at the baby, and again, when she touches its foot. Yet, her gestures are welcomed and reciprocated, she as well is looked at and touched. Their interaction remains limited to this spontaneous meeting in the café, but its link to Kay's writing process suggests that the two women's relationality is generative of a new kind of story. The encounter is in meaningful tension with the white ignorance Feigel's protagonists display throughout the novel. Kay's inability to find her voice is not only generated by the dominance of the male voices. It is also determined by not having come to terms with her whiteness and her class privilege, the first step to which, Feigel's adaptation suggests, is to risk vulnerability in spontaneous encounters.

Conclusion

This essay has explored how women's friendships in Mary McCarthy's *The Group* and its 2020 adaptation by Lara Feigel enable narratives of women's lives beyond marriage. I have asked in particular how friendships are conceptualised and represented in the narrative form in each text, and which development of novel politics can be observed in contrasting the two texts. The narrative architecture of the two novels suggests that McCarthy's text

identifies the tradition of the marriage plot as a hindrance to telling women's stories beyond marriage. Because of the novel's framing around a friendship group, expressing this critique is made possible. The most notable change Feigel makes in relation to the novel's narrative form is the first-person narrator. Her perspective adds the dyadic dimension to the relationships between the protagonists and places the focus on narrative voice rather than narrative plot in the adaptation.

The original not only establishes that stories about women are confined to the marriage plot, the text also provides deeper insight into how closely gender, sexuality and plot are linked. The novel's focus on the women's friend group achieves the queering of the narrative, allowing the critique of the marriage plot to be expressed through serialisation. However, the friendship group as narrative tool cannot bring about any innovation beyond the critique. The final chapter of McCarthy's novel seems to suggest that these narrative restrictions imposed on women narrators can only be circumvented if the protagonists cannot be forced into heteronormative narrative structures. Lesbian relationships can turn the logic of traditional narrative traditions on its head, the novel suggests. Feigel's adaptation begins where McCarthy suspected a possible narrative revolution: with Stella as a bisexual first-person narrator, queer politics are built into the design of the plot. Lesbian desire and platonic friendship are not binary opposites, but represent the complexity of relationships between women. By liberating women's stories from heteronormative plot traditions, women's friendships constitute a rescue plot.

Both novels are narrated by an omniscient narrator. McCarthy's original captures the group identity of her protagonists with the help of free indirect discourse; Feigel adds a friend to her group who conveys her own story and that of her friends in the first person. The contrast between the two novels shows the effects of the developments in indirect discourse in recent decades observed by scholars like Dawson and Pennacchio. While free indirect discourse is suitable for simultaneously depicting and criticising the protagonists' beliefs, which led researchers to focus on the critique of the friend group in McCarthy's novel, the added first-person narrator offers additional perspectives. Feigel's text can, with the help of her omniscient first-person narrator, both criticise her generation and the friendship group, but also expose the dyadic friendship relationships and the cognitive challenges that it entails to narrate them. A central challenge to narrating women's friendships according to Feigel's novel is the difficulty to disentangle one's own story from that of one's friend, and to acknowledge both sameness and difference. Free indirect discourse serves to indicate the discriminatory elements of the group identities in both novels. The focus in McCarthy's novel lies on the antisemitism which the group at first claims to reject as part of their parents' generation's backwardness, but eventually perpetuates. As the realisation is placed at the end of the novel and takes up and corrects

an assertion made at the very beginning, this criticism of the group is linked to the general questioning of the alleged progressiveness of the friends. It is telling that McCarthy's novel draws specific attention to antisemitic politics of *The Group*' narrative but that her generation's racism is barely mentioned. While McCarthy's critique of her contemporaries' hypocrisy shines through in the mentioning of Kay's and Harald's Black maid Clara, it takes up only a single page in the novel (MM, 107).[64] At the forefront of her awareness are those identities that matter to her own social circle which include notable Jewish American writers like Philip Rahv and Hannah Arendt. Feigel's *the group* also reflects on the (lack of) diversity of the friendship group. The friends are white and wealthy like McCarthy's, though in the adaptation two of them are Jewish. That their narrative is exclusionist is expressed through the 'positive racism' which they ignorantly perpetuate. At the very end of the novel, when Kay awkwardly connects with a woman of Colour, the possibility of a story about an eye-to-eye level relationship emerges, but remains untold. The friends in Feigel's novel depict a world of white London professionals who respond to their own discomfort with their privilege with a claim of colour blindness.

Contrasting the two novels has shown that narratives that are structured by women's friendships not only expose that narrative form is entangled with social categories like gender, and sexuality as Lanser established in 1996, but also with antisemitism and whiteness. Feigel's novel also emphasises the crucial role of spontaneity, chance encounters and the disentanglement of the friends from the group. In 'Against Friendship', Leah Claire Allen and John S. Garrison have argued recently that queer friendship in the form of the chosen family tends to replicate the patterns of nuclear families rather than creating radical forms of love, and are therefore regulated by similar narrative notions such as choice and futurity: 'Many queer valuations of friendship [therefore] still reinforce qualities of sameness that erase differences in race, gender and class'.[65] Not least, Feigel's argues for a departure from the friendship group as narrative form specifically because of its tendencies to be governed by sameness.

Notes

1. Mary McCarthy, *The Group* (London: Penguin, 1964). See for example Nancy K. Miller, 'Women's Secrets and the Novel: Remembering Mary McCarthy's The Group', *Social Research*, 68.1 (2001), pp. 173–99 (p. 178), or Justin David Mitchell, 'The Mary McCarthy Case', *The Mailer Review*, 14.1 (2020), pp. 123–52 (p. 137).
2. Catherine Keyser, *Playing Smart: New York Women Writers and Modern Magazine Culture* (New York, NY: Rutgers Univ. Press, 2010), p. 145.

3. Murphy, Brenda, 'The Thirties, Public and Private, A Reassessment of Mary McCarthy's "The Group"', *Literature Interpretation Theory*, 15.1 (2004), pp. 81–101 (87).
4. Miller, 'Women's Secrets and the Novel', pp. 178, 179; Jessica Apuzzo, 'On Mary McCarthy: The Responsibility of One Intellectual', in Stephen Palmer (ed.), *Between Identity and Practice. Contemporary Perspectives on the Intellectual* (Boston, MA: Brill, 2020), pp. 1–10 (2).
5. Norman Mailer, 'The Mary McCarthy Case', *The New York Review of Books*, 17 October 1963, pp. 1–3.
6. See Kelly A. Marsh, '"All My Habits of Mind": Performance and Identity in the Novels of Mary McCarthy', *Studies in the Novel*, 34.3 (2002), pp. 303–19; Avis G. Hewitt, "Myn Owene Woman, Wel at Ese"; Cassandra, 'Political Progress and Social Stall: Groupthink, Smart Talk.
7. Avis G. Hewitt, "Myn Owene Woman, Wel at Ese": Feminist Facts in the Fiction of Mary McCarthy (doctoral thesis, Ball State University, 1993), p. 175, 176, 183.
8. Fetters, (see xv).
9. Mary McCarthy, *How I Grew* (New York: Harcourt, 1987), Mary McCarthy, 'The Vassar Girl', in *On the Contrary*, (New York: Hippocrene Books, 1967), pp. 193–214; Carol Brightman (ed.), *Between Friends: The Correspondence of Hannah Arendt and Mary McCarthy* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1995).
10. Betty Friedan, *The Feminine Mystique* (New York, NY: Norton & Company, 1963).
11. Hewitt, p. 193, Miller argues that McCarthy's novel can indeed be read as a feminist endeavour, despite the authors disdain for feminism. She looks in particular at the effects of McCarthy's realism which made the supposedly private elements of women's lives public, and notes how the reactions to it exposed the hypocrisies of her fellow male writers: Nancy Miller, p. 177.
12. Lara Feigel, *The Group* (London: John Murray, 2020). All quotation of Lara Feigel's the group are indicated by her initials LF and the respective page number in brackets following the quoted passage.
13. Susan S. Lanser, 'Second Sex Economics: Race, Rescue, and the Heroine's Plot', *The Eighteenth Century,* 61.2 (2020), pp. 227–44.
14. Lanser, 'Second Sex Economics: Race, Rescue, and the Heroine's Plot', p. 242.
15. Ibid.
16. Rishoi, pp. 25, 26.
17. Ibid.
18. Ibid., p. 328.
19. All quotations of Mary McCarthy's The Group are indicated by her initials LF and the respective page number in brackets following the quoted passage.
20. See also Cassandra Fetters, 'Political Progress and Social Stall: Groupthink, Smart Talk, and Mary McCarthy's Friendship Novel', in K. Branham and K.L. Reames (eds), *Navigating Women's Friendships in American Literature and Culture,* American Literature Readings in the 21st Century (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2023), p. 65.
21. Mary-Catherine Harrison, 'Reading the Marriage Plot', *Journal of Family Theory and Review*, 6 (2014), pp. 112–31.
22. Ibid., pp. 112–31 (113, 114).
23. Robyn Warhol, 'Queering the Marriage Plot: How Serial Form Works in Maupin's *Tales of the City*', in Brian Richardson (ed.), *Narrative Dynamics:*

Essays on Time, Plot, Closure, and Frames (Columbus: The Ohio State University Press, 2002), pp. 229–48 (p. 232). See also Sam McBean, 'We Fuck and Friends Don't Fuck': BFFs, Lesbian Desire, and Queer Narratives', *Textual Practice*, 32.6 (2018), pp. 957–72, p. 926.

24. Ibid.
25. Rachel Blau DuPlessis, *Writing beyond the Ending* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1985), p. 1. See also Kristi Branham and Kelly L. Reames, 'Introduction. Navigating Women's Friendships into the Twenty-First Century', in *Navigating Women's Friendships in American Literature and Culture* (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2023), pp. 1–12 (1).
26. Review of 'The Group', by Mary McCarthy, *Newsweek,* a (1963), pp. 80–3 (81).
27. Susan S. Lanser, 'Queering Narrative Voice'. *Textual Practice*, 32.6 (2018), pp. 923–37 (928).
28. Susan S. Lanser, 'Queering Narratology', in Kathy Mezei (ed.), *Ambiguous Discourse. Feminist Narratology and British Women Writers* (Chapel Hill, NC: Univ. of North Carolina Press, 1996), pp. 250–61 (259),
29. Judith Roof, *Come as You Are: Sexuality and Narrative* (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 1996), pp. 82, 83.
30. Murphy, p. 84.
31. Ibid.
32. Marsh, 310.
33. Ibid.
34. D.A. Miller, *Jane Austen, or the Secret of Style* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton Univ. Press, 2005).
35. Ibid., p. 58.; See also Paul Dawson, *The Return of the Omniscient Narrator: Authorship and Authority in Twenty-First Century Fiction* (Columbus, OH: Ohio State Univ. Press, 2013), pp. 167, 168.
36. Miller, p. 27.
37. Ibid.
38. Ibid., p. 59.
39. Ibid., pp. 42, 71.
40. Monika Fludernik, 'Second Person Narrative as a Test Case for Narratology: The Limits of Realism', *Style*, 28, no. 3 (1994): pp. 445–75 (471). For the different possible referees of the second person, see for example: Bettina Kluge, 'Generic Uses of the Second Person Singular – How Speakers Deal with Referential Ambiguity and Misunderstandings', *Pragmatics*, 26.3 (2016), pp. 501–22, especially 504.
41. For an updated overview see also: Violeta Sotirova. "The status of the narrator in Modernist fiction." *Journal of Literary Semantics*, 49.2 (2020), pp. 75–97, especially 83–8.
42. Gérard Genette, *Narrative Discourse* (Ithaka, NY: Cornell Univ. Press, 1980), 195.
43. Filippo Pennacchio, '"Enhanced "I"s: Omniscience and Third-Person Features in Contemporary First-Person Narrative Fiction', *Narrative*, 28.1 (2020), pp. 21–42.; Dawson sees the return of the omniscient narrator in contemporary literature in interdependency with the increasingly public persona of fiction authors. On a formal level, he emphasises that contemporary omniscient voices, in particular free indirect discourse, reflect on the narratorial performance of authority. see Dawson, 2013.
44. Ibid., p. 25.

45. Dawson, *The Return of the Omniscient Narrator*, p. 196.
46. Pennacchio, p. 38.
47. Ibid.
48. Dawson, *The Return of Omniscient Narrator*, p. 210.
49. Hewitt, p. 174, Marsh, p. 310, 311.
50. Lara Feigel, *Free Woman. Life, Liberation and Doris Lessing* (London: Bloomsbury, 2018), p. 242. Feigel's memoir is dedicated to her friends, and relates friendship very closely with freedom. See also p. 306.
51. Thomas Malory, *Le Morte D'Arthur*. Book 3, Chapter IV.
52. Corinne Saunders, 'The Affective Body: Love, Virtue and Vision in English Medieval Literature', in Corinne Saunders et al. (eds), *The Body and the Arts,* (London: Palgrave, 2009), pp. 87–102 (90). Thomas Malory, Le Morte D'Arthur, Book 6, Chapters XIV and XV.
53. Malory, Book 7, Chapters II-XXIII.
54. Stephen Orgel, 'The Comedian as the Character C', *English Comedy*, Michael Cordner, Peter Holland, and John Kerrigan (ed.) (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 38.
55. Freddie Rokem, *Philosophers and Thespians: Thinking Performances* (Redwood City: Stanford Univ. Press, 2018), p. 64.
56. Andrew Hui, 'Horatio's Philosophy in Hamlet', *Renaissance Drama,* 41.1 (2013), pp. 151–233 (152).
57. Will Norman, 'Complicit Atmospheres: Anti-Semitism and Midcentury U.S. Fiction', *Comparative Literature Studies*, 56.4 (2019), pp. 731–49 (740).
58. Ibid., pp, 733, 743.
59. Fetters, p. 65.
60. Joshua Landy, 'In Praise of Depth: or, How I Stopped Worrying and Learned to Love the Hidden', *New Literary History*, 51 (2020), pp. 145–76.
61. For an overview of the racist discourses potentially connected to mixed race children of white women and Black men, see the literature review of Erica Chito Childs, 'Looking behind the Stereotypes of the "Angry Black Woman": An Exploration of Black Women's Responses to Interracial Relationships', *Gender and Society,* 19.4 (2005), pp. 544–61, especially 546–8.
62. Tamari Kitossa, *Appealing Because He Is Appalling: Black Masculinities, Colonialism and Erotic Racism* (Alberta: University of Alberta Press, 2021), pp. 7–14. See also Kenny Monrose's ethnographic study of Black men's identities in Britain, in which he shows that sexual objectification of the body continues to impact the construction of Black British masculinities in Post-Windrush generations: Kenny Monrose, *Black Men in Britain. An Ethnographic Portrait of the Post-Windrush Generation* (London: Routledge, 2019), specifically 70–2.
63. In *Becoming Black*, Michelle Wright argues that Black women in Britain are denied subject status as the 'other of the other', Michelle M. Wright, *Becoming Black: Creating Identity in the African Diaspora* (Duke University Press, 2004), pp. 197–224. Feigel's novel draws attention to this absence of Black women in the lives of *the group* accurately. Women of Colour in the novel are restricted to professional contexts, while Black men are friends and sexual partners.
64. On her critique on the mere performance of solidarity with the working class, see for example: Mary McCarthy, *The Company She Keeps* (London: Hachette, 2011 [1939]), pp. 146, 147.

65. Leah C. Allen and John S. Garrison, '10 Against Friendship', in Tyler Bradway and Elizabeth Freeman (eds), *Queer Kinship: Race, Sex, Belonging, Form,* (New York: Duke Univ. Press, 2022), pp. 227–47 (232).

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